

Chapter 41-1: Yearning

The faint taste of blood spread along her lips. Before Ning Fuyi could transfer a breath of energy, she received a slap across her face, then was forcefully pushed away.

Although it was called a slap, the force was like a mosquito bite—it didn't hurt at all, but it was enough to make her freeze.

The woman who had been unconscious moments before had somehow opened her eyes, her autumn-water pupils¹ full of surprise and anger.

"What are you doing!" she said.

Ning Fuyi touched her lips: "You're not dead?"

"Who told you I was dead?" Chu Qingqiu used her sleeve to wipe away the blood traces on her mouth, using great force as if trying to wipe away Ning Fuyi's scent.

Ning Fuyi watched her actions. As her panicked heart settled, her ears noticeably began to heat up. She suddenly moved away from Chu Qingqiu's side, muttering: "Who told you to suddenly stop breathing? I was transferring energy to you, as if I wanted to do it."

Chu Qingqiu's hair hung disheveled. She covered half her face with her sleeve, her expression unreadable, saying coldly: "Did Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate never teach you about the Turtle Breath Technique²?"

When severely injured, one could use turtle breathing to heal, allowing the fastest recovery of immortal meridians and qi and blood.

"Of course they taught it, but you should have informed me before entering turtle breathing," Ning Fuyi said sulkily. She sat down with a thump, scooting aside to sit alongside Chu Qingqiu.

The hall was silent for a long while, then Chu Qingqiu's voice suddenly came: "I apologize."

Ning Fuyi was somewhat surprised. To hear an apology from someone like Chu Qingqiu was harder than climbing to heaven.

"Forget it, it's nothing," Ning Fuyi sighed. "We're going to die sooner or later anyway. You were right—there's no path ahead."

After all this turmoil, now completely collapsed and sitting, surrounded by silence, she could finally feel her body's exhaustion. Ning Fuyi was still a mortal body after all, and hadn't reached the fasting stage³. Now drowsiness struck, and her eyelids felt somewhat heavy.

She leaned back against the stone behind her, gazing absently at the two corpses in front of her while dozing off. Before long, her body suddenly tilted to one side, and her head was about to hit the ground.

A hand suddenly reached out from beside her, catching her cheek. Ning Fuyi licked her lips and continued sleeping peacefully in that palm.

Chu Qingqiu frowned as she looked at her, shaking her head.

"Really such a child's temperament, able to fall asleep at any time," she said as her eyes lowered. She didn't let go of her hand, nor did she wake Ning Fuyi, but let her sleep soundly.

After an unknown amount of time, Chu Qingqiu's hand became somewhat sore. She hesitated for a moment, then suddenly shifted her body toward Ning Fuyi's side, letting her lean against her shoulder.

The young woman's breathing was regular, making extremely soft snoring sounds. The warmth of her cheek transmitted through the clothes on her shoulder.

As Chu Qingqiu watched, her gaze moved downward to settle on those cherry-like lips. Those lips looked soft, and felt soft too when touched...

She suddenly clenched her palm until it hurt, only then jerking her gaze away, closing her eyes to circulate energy, letting her cold body gradually warm up.

After about half an hour, Ning Fuyi finally woke up. The exhaustion throughout her body had diminished considerably. She stretched lazily, and when her head moved, she realized she was lying on Chu Qingqiu's shoulder. Her movements froze for an instant before she carefully lifted her head.

Chu Qingqiu was still meditating with closed eyes, saying nothing.

Perhaps she had been unable to support herself while sleeping and had slumped over. Ning Fuyi touched her nose. However, that Chu Qingqiu hadn't woken her but had let her sleep was unexpected.

No matter what, people had strength after sleeping. Ning Fuyi exhaled a long breath, supporting herself on the rocks to climb up, continuing to circle among the rubble, trying to find some clues.

Chu Qingqiu opened her eyes, silently watching Ning Fuyi's back. Some immortal energy had recovered in her depleted body, so she raised her hand. A faint light rose from her fingertip, floating toward the depths of the ruins and stopping at a collapsed wall.

Then, enduring the pain throughout her body, she struggled to stand up. However, her legs went weak and her body swayed, nearly falling.

"What's wrong?" Ning Fuyi, hearing the sound, ran toward her. Seeing that she had actually stood up, she quickly grasped her arm to support her back down, frowning: "You're injured like this and still trying to show off?"

"What are you looking for?" As soon as she finished speaking, she saw the light point in the distance, so she said no more. Her body transformed into flowing light, landing at that spot in the next instant. She bent down to push away the stone slabs, lifting out the dirty Bai Lin from inside.

Bai Lin's breathing was weak, whimpering softly, using its furry head to nuzzle against Ning Fuyi's arm in a way that made one's heart ache.

Ning Fuyi held it tightly in her arms, then returned to Chu Qingqiu's side, handing Bai Lin to her. Chu Qingqiu said nothing more, just took out a pill from her waist and fed it to the tiger. Then, with a light touch of her fingertip, Bai Lin disappeared.

"Is it all right?" Ning Fuyi couldn't help asking.

"It's fine. White tigers are divine beasts⁴—it just needs to sleep for a while," Chu Qingqiu said. She leaned back against the stone, seemingly having expended much energy getting up.

"Knowing you're injured and still showing off, just ask me for help," Ning Fuyi said.

"I can do it myself..."

"Look, you always put on that Divine Venerable airs of yours, as if you don't need anyone and don't care about anyone. That's why I used to dislike you so much," Ning Fuyi said. Since they couldn't get out anyway, her mouth had no filter.

Chu Qingqiu fell silent but didn't refute.

"There's nothing left here except those two corpses. Since they're ancient gods and demons, they might have some clues on them, but you won't let me touch them," Ning Fuyi said, then suddenly suggested: "Why don't I take you over there so you can look personally?"

This time Chu Qingqiu finally agreed. A faint red color appeared under her eyes as she extended her hand toward Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi was stunned for a moment before realizing what she meant. She actually felt somewhat honored, so she grasped her palm with her right hand and supported her waist with her left, pulling her up with some effort.

Half-supporting, half-embracing, she brought her to the front of the corpses.

Unlike Ning Fuyi's complete lack of restraint, Chu Qingqiu first placed her hand on her chest. Her beautiful head bowed slightly as she said quietly, "Excuse me," then spread her five fingers. White mist rose from her palm as she passed it over the clothing of the corpses.

"Two women," Chu Qingqiu parted her lips slightly, speaking slowly and gently. "One died from a sharp weapon piercing her heart and lungs, the other as well."

"I told you it was mutual destruction," Ning Fuyi said.

Chu Qingqiu ignored her, her palm continuing to pass over the surface of the corpses: "The demon clan member was devoured by powerful force before death. If I'm not mistaken, it should have been that divine sword."

Ning Fuyi looked up. The divine sword seemed to have heard and tilted its hilt to one side, like a person tilting their head.

Ning Fuyi's eyelid twitched as she turned her gaze back: "What about the god?"

Chu Qingqiu placed her hand on the corpse's chest, saying "Excuse me, predecessor" again before lifting her clothing and touching something. Her eyes flashed.

She moved her fingertip slightly, pulling out what she had touched. Ning Fuyi suddenly heard the sound of wind, and then the light before her eyes suddenly disappeared.

Footnotes:

¹ **Autumn-water pupils (剪水秋眸)** - A poetic way to describe beautiful, clear eyes that sparkle like autumn water.

² **Turtle Breath Technique (龟息功)** - A meditation and healing technique that dramatically slows breathing and heart rate, making one appear dead while actually recovering from injuries.

³ **Fasting stage (辟谷)** - A level in cultivation where practitioners no longer need to eat regular food, instead sustaining themselves on spiritual energy.

⁴ **Divine beasts (神兽)** - Mythical creatures with supernatural powers, often serving as companions to powerful cultivators or deities.